

Unit 1, Option C: The British Empire: Colonisation and Decolonisation

Topic C1: The Origins of the British Empire, c1680-1763

The focus of this topic is on Britain's acquisition of overseas territories in years c1680-1763. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which focus exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

The content bullet points should not each be considered in isolation. Students should understand links between factors such as commercial success (bullet 1), the acquisition of territory and the need for government regulation and support (bullets 2 and 3), and the ways in which they interacted to bring about the growth of empire. This in turn created diplomatic rivalries and wars, often resulting in further growth. Collectively the bullet points offer a framework for understanding how trade became empire.

The first bullet point addresses the importance of trade and commerce in stimulating the growth of empire. Students should understand the role of merchants and joint stock companies in developing trade and providing the framework from which the Empire grew, and should be able to illustrate this by reference to companies such as the East India, Royal African and South Sea companies. They should also be aware of conflicts with rivals, especially from other European states. Internal problems, for example in India, are not addressed in this bullet point: the main focus should be on the ways in which the activities of the companies and their need for protection and defence led to the acquisition of territory and stimulated the growth of empire.

The second bullet point focuses on the role of government in imperial expansion. Students may be aware of naval expansion in the mid-17th century, stimulated by colonial settlement and civil war, and of the passing of the first Navigation Acts, but they are not required to have knowledge of events before 1680. The main focus should be on the impact of the acts and the development of mercantilist policies. They should understand that their success stimulated imperial ambitions while the profits made it possible to pursue them. This can be illustrated by reference to the growth of London and other ports and the political effects as demonstrated in government policy and priorities. Reference can also be made to government efforts to encourage colonial foundations.